

The Makgadikgadi Pan

Location Kalahari Desert, northeast Botswana

This is actually a group of enormous salt pans, together making up one of the largest in the world, with an area of 6,200 square miles (16,000 square km). The Sua, Nwetwe, Nxai, and other pans are relics of the formerly huge Lake Makgadikgadi, which dried up several thousand years ago. Almost lifeless dry, salty crusts for most of the year, they are fed fresh water seasonally by the Nata, Boteti, and other rivers. This encourages the growth of vegetation around their margins and attracts migrant ducks, flamingos, and other birds. The Makgadikgadi pan is home to one of only two breeding populations of greater flamingos in southern Africa.

Other deserts in Africa

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- The Karoo » p.211
- The Namib Desert » pp.212-13
- The Sahara Desert » pp.208-209
- The White Desert » p.210

Asia

The Kyzylkum Desert

Location Between the Amu Darya and Syr Darya rivers in Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, and Turkmenistan

Sloping gently northwest toward the Aral Sea between the Amu Darya and Syr Darya rivers, this arid region of 116,000 square miles (300,000 square km) of sand dunes is occasionally punctuated by highlands, such as the Bukantau, Tamdytau, and

◀ THE MAKGADIKGADI PAN

Auminzatau mountains. Another feature of the desert is the presence of takirs: shallow hollows that are submerged after seasonal rains and dry out to form cracked crusts when the water evaporates. Annual rainfall averages just 6 in (150 mm), while temperatures fluctuate greatly from 86°F (30°C) or more in summer to 16°F (-9°C) in winter.

The Syrian Desert

Location Southern Syria, western Iraq, northeast Jordan, and northern Saudi Arabia

Covering a vast area of true desert and steppe, the Syrian Desert comprises an elevated plateau in southern Syria and eastern Jordan, and a plain that gently slopes northeast toward the Euphrates River. The whole area is dissected by wadis (dry valleys). Annual rainfall is as low as 4 in (100 mm) in some areas. Daytime temperatures reach 113°F (45°C) in summer, and a hot, dry wind called the khamsin frequently sweeps across the desert from the south or southeast, blowing up duststorms. The southern part of the desert is inhabited by several nomadic tribes and breeders of Arabian horses.

The Dasht-e-Kavir Desert

Location Southeast of Tehran, in northern Iran

Extending 240 miles (390 km) from the Alborz mountains southeast to the Dasht-e-Lut desert, this extremely arid region is surrounded on all sides by mountains. Although it receives virtually no rainfall, runoff from the mountains flows into seasonal lakes and the salt marshes of Kavir Buzorg, where evaporation leads to the formation of a salty surface crust. Rig Jenn is a vast area of sand dunes where summer temperatures can reach 122°F (50°C). The Kavir

National Park has a small population of the critically endangered Asiatic cheetah.

The Indus Valley Desert

Location Between the Chenub and Indus rivers, northwest Punjab province, Pakistan

This inhospitable plain, which covers 7,700 square miles (20,000 square km), bakes in temperatures up to 113°F (45°C) during the day in summer, but can be freezing in winter. Annual rainfall ranges from 24 in to 31 in (600 mm to 800 mm), and a variety of vegetation reflects this. Drought-resistant *Prosopis* shrubs and trees are plentiful. Five large mammal species are native to the desert: the Indian wolf, striped hyena, caracal, Indian leopard, and urial (a form of wild sheep).

Other deserts in Asia

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- The Dasht-e-Lut » p.263
- The Gobi Desert » pp.266-67
- The Karakum Desert » p.264
- The Taklamakan Desert » p.264
- The Thar Desert » p.265

Australia and New Zealand

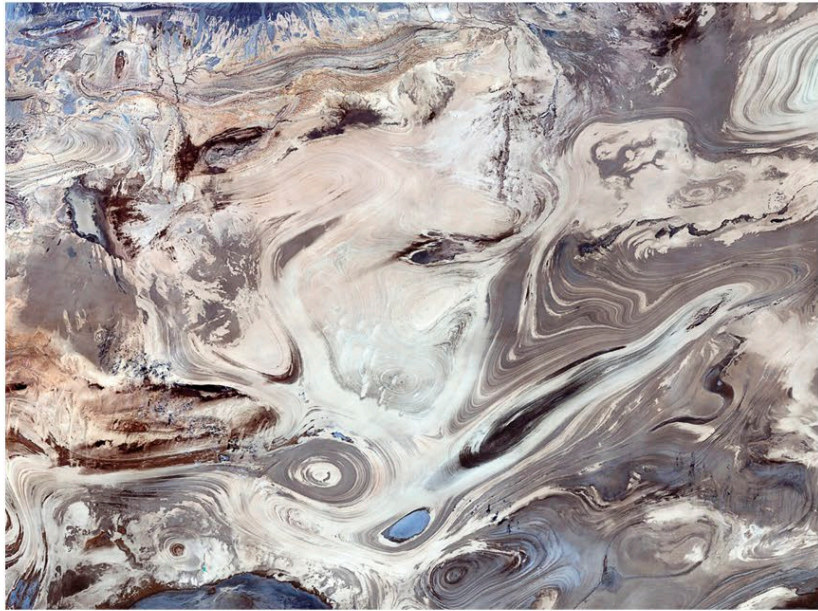
The Little Sandy Desert

Location Between Newman and Wiluna in Western Australia

Covering an area of 42,500 square miles (110,000 square km), this undulating country of red dune fields is vegetated by acacia and drought-resistant spinifex grass. The landscape is sometimes broken by escarpments of ancient sandstone, such as the Calvert Range. In the north of the desert is Lake Disappointment, an endorheic salt lake, which holds water only in very wet periods.

Other deserts in Australia and New Zealand

- The Gibson Desert » p.298
- The Great Sandy Desert » p.295
- The Great Victoria Desert » p.299
- The Pinnacles » p.298
- The Simpson Desert » pp.296-97



▲ SALT MARSHES OF THE DASHT-E-KAVIR DESERT